

3.4.2 Strategies for production

Research and experience show that people who communicate effectively in a foreign language tend to make good use of systematic efficient verbal and non-verbal strategies to get meaning across, in spite of their imperfect command of the language.

Individual students may fail to learn – or forget – language items required by some tests, or they may wish to attempt to go beyond the demands of the specification in completing the task set. In

these circumstances, the following strategies can prove useful. They fall into two main categories: non-verbal and verbal.

3.4.2.1 Non-verbal strategies

Pointing and demonstration

This may be accompanied by some appropriate language (eg "*Comme ça...*" "*Qu'est-ce que c'est ?*" "*Ça fait mal ici*").

Expression and gesture

This may be accompanied, where appropriate, with sounds (eg "*Oh !*" which, with appropriate intonation, facial expression and gestures, can convey such attitudes and functions as pain, surprise, anger, fear, pleasure and admiration).

Mime

This can be accompanied by appropriate sounds and language and can sometimes help communication to be maintained when it might otherwise break down (eg "*Je peux vous aider ?*" with a suitable mime if one has forgotten the words such as "*balayer*" and "*essuyer*"). This strategy has obvious limitations in a speaking test which is recorded and assessed on the basis of the recording.

Drawing

This can be an efficient strategy with some tasks (especially written) and can convey both attitude and information (eg a diagram showing how to get from one point, such as a station, to another, for instance a home).

3.4.2.2 Verbal strategies

Using a word which refers to a similar item

Using a word which refers to a similar item to the one the speaker/writer wishes to refer to, but for which he/she has forgotten the word (eg *montre* for *horloge*, *tasse* for *verre*, *fleur* for *rose* or *prêter* for *louer*). This is not always effective and its use would be assessed according to its effectiveness in a particular context.

Description of physical properties

This can be used to refer to something when the name has been forgotten (eg "*c'est rond... le fruit jaune... l'objet qu'on voit sur la table...*"). The physical properties refer to colour, size, material, position and shape. The use of this strategy in an exam would be assessed according to its communicative effectiveness.

Requests for help

These can include requests for rewording (eg "*Comment dit-on 'chair' en français... ?*" "*Qu'est-ce que cela veut dire en anglais ?*") and questions; which make no reference to English (eg "*Comment s'appelle cette machine-là ?*" "...*Ça s'écrit comment ?*"). It is clearly preferable to use such requests for help than for communication to collapse and their use will be assessed according to the context. When requests for help with specific problems occur, the teacher should maintain the role of a sympathetic native speaker and help accordingly. The teacher should avoid taking over from the student and carrying out the tasks set.

Simplification

This is when a student avoids the use of a form of which he/she is unsure (eg "*il faut que je m'en aille*"... "*je viendrai s'il fait beau*") by using a form he/she finds simpler (eg "*je dois partir*"... "*je viens s'il fait beau*"). When such simple forms are used correctly and appropriately they will be rewarded accordingly. Correct and appropriate use of more complex forms will also be rewarded.

A systematic use of simplified forms may reduce error, facilitate communication and increase fluency but, if overused, this strategy may result in students failing to make full use of their capabilities.

Paraphrase

This is where the student uses words and messages in acceptable French, avoiding the use of words which he/she has forgotten (eg "*Elle n'est pas mariée*" for "*Elle est célibataire*", "*C'est comme un...*" "*C'est le contraire de...*" "*C'est une sorte de...*" "*Je voudrais une tranche de cette viande-là*"). When used well, this strategy communicates the message effectively to a sympathetic native speaker and such use in an exam would be assessed accordingly.

Reference to specific features

Reference to specific features (eg "*L'animal aux longues oreilles...*" "*La jeune fille qui porte des lunettes...*") is often quite effective and its use would be assessed accordingly in an exam.

Reference to the function of an object

Reference to the function of an object and the actions that can be performed with it (eg "*L'objet qu'on utilise pour ouvrir une bouteille*") is a commonly used strategy which is usually effective in communicative terms.

Word coinage

Another strategy sometimes used by language learners is word coinage, the creation of words based either on English or French words. This strategy usually produces words which do not exist in French or, if they do exist, have a different meaning from the one intended. The use of this strategy is rarely effective in promoting communication and students would be well advised to use it only if all other strategies fail.

Topic avoidance

Another commonly used strategy is topic avoidance, when the student avoids or abandons a topic because of inability to deal with it. Use of this strategy in the exam will not allow the student to be given full credit. Use of it in a learning situation will reduce opportunities for the development or expansion of the student's repertoire. It is a strategy which should be discouraged. A basic condition for communication strategies to have a potential learning effect is that they are governed by achievement, rather than avoidance behaviour.

Evidence suggests that the availability of a range of strategies such as those outlined above, and flexibility in their use, represent an important advantage in overall communicative effectiveness. It also appears that the most effective strategies demand some linguistic proficiency and that the more proficient speakers are also better at using communication strategies effectively.

The development of such strategies cannot be seen as encouragement not to develop linguistic knowledge. Strategic competence is not a substitute for vocabulary learning, but a useful supplement. All language users make use of communication strategies, even in their first language, and really successful strategies usually pass unnoticed. It is an important part of the teaching and learning process.